

## YOUTH IN ORAKZAI SOCIETY

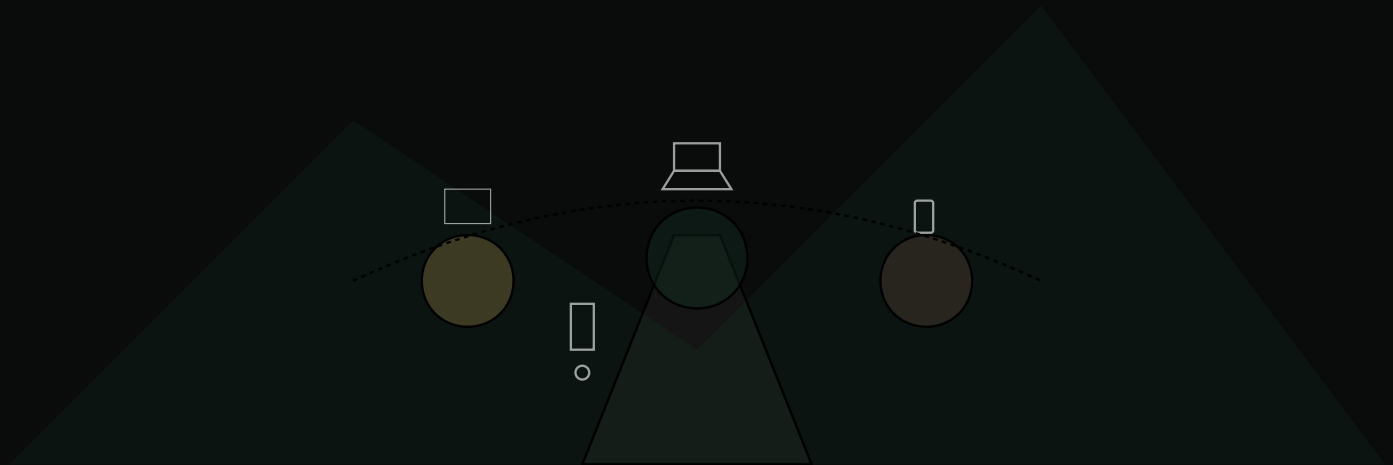
“A new generation carries an old memory into a changing world.”

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Every generation inherits a world it did not create. And every generation changes the world it inherits. For young people in Orakzai communities, that space between inheritance and change can be especially important. They may grow up hearing Pashto at home while studying in another language at school. They may know stories from grandparents while communicating with friends through a smartphone. They may participate in Eid, weddings and family gatherings while building careers in cities far from the mountains. They may respect traditions while asking questions about which traditions should continue. Youth therefore are not simply the future of Orakzai. They are part of its present. They study. They work. They play. They migrate. They create businesses. They use technology. They preserve culture. And sometimes, they redefine it. The story of Orakzai youth is therefore a story of continuity, choice and change.

# YOUTH IN ORAKZAI SOCIETY

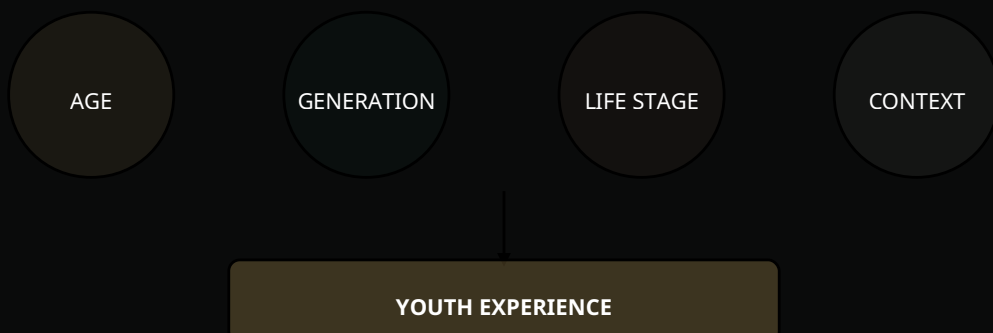
"A new generation carries an old memory into a changing world."



"The synthesis of tradition, innovation, and future aspirations among Orakzai youth."

## THE EXPERIENCE OF YOUTH

The definition of "youth" varies, but it is fundamentally a social stage defined by the transition from dependence to responsibility. For Orakzai youth, this experience is shaped by age, generation, and the specific social context of their family and village. They navigate a world where traditional expectations of guidance and honor coexist with modern choices in education, career, and digital participation.



“The demographic and social components of the youth experience.”

ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC

PASHTUN-WIDE

REGIONAL

FAMILY-SPECIFIC

CONTEMPORARY

SOCIAL COHESION AND COMMUNITY ROLE

Young people in Orakzai are active participants in community life. Research by J. Alam (2024) identifies youth as "local supporters" who play a vital role in promoting social cohesion. They act as bridges during community transitions, helping to stabilize the social fabric through civic participation and peacebuilding efforts. This role is often facilitated by modern platforms like FM radio, which provides a space for youth engagement and dialogue.<sup>1,2</sup>

LOCAL SUPPORTERS

Youth Civic Action

SOCIAL COHESION

Stability & Peace

DISTRICT FUTURE

“The role of youth in maintaining and building social cohesion in Orakzai.”

EDUCATION AND ASPIRATIONS

Education is the primary vehicle for youth aspiration. While Orakzai faces significant educational disparities—with female literacy below 30% (2023 Census)—the drive for learning remains strong. Young people pursue medicine, engineering, and technology, often migrating to urban centers for higher education. This pursuit creates a cycle of knowledge acquisition that benefits both the individual and their home community.<sup>4,5</sup>

EDUCATION

KNOWLEDGE

SKILLS

OPPORTUNITY

ASPIRATION PATHWAY

“The education-to-opportunity model for Orakzai youth.”

## SPORTS AND PHYSICAL CULTURE

Sports are a cornerstone of youth life in Orakzai. The 2024 and 2026 Spring Festivals documented high participation in both traditional sports like kabaddi and wrestling, and modern ones like volleyball and cricket. Successes such as Sajawal Ali's 2026 gold medal in volleyball demonstrate the talent and potential of the district's youth. Sports serve as a platform for intergenerational gathering, tribal pride, and physical development.<sup>3</sup>

### Traditional Sports

Preserving heritage through Kabaddi, Wrestling, and Horse/Camel dances at festivals.

### Modern Excellence

Achieving national success in Volleyball and Cricket, bridging Orakzai with Pakistan's sports scene.

## DIGITAL IDENTITY AND CULTURAL ARCHIVING

Technology has created a new information space for Orakzai youth. They use social media and smartphones not just for communication, but for cultural preservation. By recording elders, documenting family histories, and digitizing Pashto poetry, young people have become the active archivists of their heritage. AI is emerging as a supportive tool for transcription and translation, though its use requires careful verification to ensure cultural accuracy.

ELDER STORY

YOUTH LISTENER

DIGITAL RECORD

FUTURE ARCHIVE

“The intergenerational archiving workflow enabled by youth and technology.”

#### AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Youth is often called the future, but in Orakzai, youth is the vibrant heartbeat of the present. Our young people are navigating a world of unprecedented change—from the mountain valleys to the digital frontier. They carry the weight of ancestral memory while building the infrastructure of tomorrow. Their responsibility is not just to preserve the past, but to adapt it, to question it respectfully, and to ensure that Orakzai identity remains relevant in a globalized world. To be Orakzai and young is to be a bridge between worlds. In their success, their learning, and their resilience, we see the enduring strength of our people.

“INNOVATION IS THE FRUIT OF TRADITION.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS

